

Measuring Democratic Backsliding: Concepts, Variables, and the Comparability Problem

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This note gives a structured way to think through the Little and Meng (2024) measurement debate. The argument proceeds in paragraphs supported by three compact tables organizing scattered facts and distinctions. The thread is: abstract concepts become concrete variables and measures; claims about democratic trends depend critically on cross-temporal comparability; subjective expert-coded and objective factual indicators tell different stories about recent decades; that divergence demands explanation grounded in both measurement logic and empirical patterns.

1 The concept-variable-measure chain

Democracy is inherently multidimensional. To study democratic change systematically, we select a variable mapping part of the democracy concept and then specify a concrete coding rule. This chain from concept to variable to measure (CVM) is not academic bookkeeping—it structures what we can claim. Minimalist electoral conceptions yield variables like incumbent defeat frequency, winner vote dominance, or legal multiparty status. Maximalist conceptions add dimensions such as civil liberties and judicial independence, but they introduce more judgment points where measurement standards can drift when comparing 2000 to 2020. Little and Meng’s core methodological question is not whether democracy is complex but whether the measurement instruments used to declare global democratic decline are sufficiently stable over time to warrant that interpretation.

2 Validity versus cross-temporal comparability

Validity asks whether a variable genuinely captures the concept at a given moment. Cross-temporal comparability asks whether a numerical score means the same substantive thing in 2000 and 2020. Expert-coded indicators can achieve high validity as snapshots while drifting if coder judgment standards tighten in response to increased media attention,

Term	What it captures	Why it matters for trends
Concept	Abstract idea (e.g., democracy as free elections + liberties + constraints)	Defines scope of what we track; different definitions lead to different variables
Variable	Observable property mapping the concept (e.g., incumbent loss rate, media freedom score)	Operationalizes concept; makes empirical study possible; choice affects what we can detect
Measure	Specific coding procedure yielding variable values (e.g., rules for counting “loss”)	Determines reliability and comparability; vague rules invite drift across time periods

Table 1: The concept-variable-measure framework and its implications

improved information environments, or evolving scholarly discourse. Objective indicators sacrifice conceptual breadth but offer stronger cross-time stability because their coding rules rest on observable facts rather than threshold assessments requiring subjective calibration. Since democratic backsliding is fundamentally a trend claim, comparability stands at the center of methodological scrutiny. A decline visible only in measures potentially subject to time-varying standards raises the question: are we observing regime change or yardstick recalibration?

Measurement quality	Core question	What threatens it
Validity	Does this variable actually capture the concept we define?	Poor concept-variable mapping; irrelevant proxies; conceptual confusion
Cross-temporal comparability	Does a score mean the same thing across years?	Coder standard drift; information availability changes; evolving base-lines; detection improvements
	Little & Meng’s argument	Implication
Validity concern?	Not their primary critique of V-Dem (asking experts about free elections has face validity)	The problem is not that variables are invalid snapshots
Comparability concern?	Yes—expert standards may have tightened over time without real institutional change	A “7” in 2010 may represent worse democracy than a “7” in 2020 due to stricter grading

Table 2: Two measurement problems and Little & Meng’s focus

3 Subjective versus objective indicators

Expert assessments can detect what legal texts and vote counts miss: informal media capture, subtle judicial pressure, or degraded pre-election conditions. Factual measures of incumbent performance, winner dominance, legal opposition status, or constitutional constraints offer narrower scope but resist mood-driven recalibration. A methodologically careful analyst does not privilege either indicator family categorically. The productive question is whether they converge when answering time-series questions about global patterns. When they diverge—as Little and Meng document—we must investigate whether

the gap reflects substantive reality or measurement artifact. If only subjective indicators show decline while objective indicators remain stable, time-varying coder bias becomes a plausible competing explanation to actual democratic erosion.

4 What the empirical patterns show

Since approximately 2000, most objective global indicators appear flat or modestly improving: incumbents are not systematically winning at higher rates; electoral winners show decreasing dominance on average; legal multiparty competition remains high and stable; formal executive constraints have not collapsed. Journalist imprisonment increased (concerning) but murders decreased (encouraging), yielding ambiguous net movement. Meanwhile, V-Dem and Freedom House aggregates show modest declines during the same period. This divergence is consistent with two distinct stories. First, time-varying coder standards: expanded information and intensified backsliding discourse lead experts to apply stricter thresholds even when institutions remain relatively stable. Second, strategic substitution: leaders adopt subtler authoritarian tools that experts perceive but objective indicators miss. The second account must reconcile with the absence of clear incumbent electoral entrenchment—a difficult task if the subtle tools are genuinely effective at consolidating power.

Indicator (global aggregate)	Type	2000–2021	Interpretation for “global backsliding” claim
Incumbent party loss rate	Obj.	b	No entrenchment; stable ~30–40%
Winner vote/seat shares	Obj.	↓	More competition; contradicts backsliding
Multiparty competition index	Obj.	b(<i>high</i>)	Stable near ceiling; violations rare
Constitutional exec. constraints	Obj.	b/↑	Term limits, dismissal rules stable/increasing
Journalists jailed	Obj.	↑	Concerning increase since early 2000s
Journalists murdered	Obj.	↓	Decrease since 2008; offsetting signal
Composite objective index	Obj.	↑	2020 near peak (unweighted)
V-Dem, Freedom House	Subj.	↓(modest)	Small declines; within uncertainty
Pattern	Subjective decline + objective stability = comparability problem or strategic substitution		

Table 3: Evidence scorecard: what different indicators show about democratic trends

5 Understanding distributional patterns

Aggregate stability could mask offsetting country-level trends—many backsliding, many improving, yielding flat averages. Little and Meng test this by examining distributions of democratic change across five-year periods. If widespread backsliding were occurring, recent distributions should show many countries with large negative changes (left tail concentration) or bimodal patterns (backsliders versus improvers). Instead, recent period distributions are *more concentrated near zero* for both objective and subjective indices. Fewer countries experience large changes in either direction. The 1990s show wide distributions reflecting substantial post-Cold War transitions; the 2010s show narrow distributions indicating stagnation rather than turbulent backsliding. When separating democracies from

autocracies, both regime types display stability since 2000 after 1990s changes. The aggregate pattern is not explained by offsetting cross-regime trends but rather by genuine within-regime stability.

6 Scope limitations and the “stacked deck” question

Little and Meng acknowledge their objective indicators emphasize electoral democracy: competitive elections, incumbent turnover, legal opposition, constitutional constraints. What these measures inadequately capture includes civil liberties enforcement, judicial independence in practice, minority rights protection, and subtle media manipulation through economic pressure rather than formal censorship. Contemporary backsliding scholarship argues modern authoritarians preserve electoral shells while eroding other democratic pillars. Hungary under Orban exemplifies this: regular elections coexist with systematic media capture and judicial politicization. On Little and Meng’s electoral indicators, Hungary might appear relatively normal; expert assessments incorporating broader dimensions would be harsher. The critical question is whether this indicator choice “stacks the deck” against finding backsliding. Little and Meng’s position: if *massive global* backsliding is occurring as claimed, electoral outcomes should reflect it. Leaders successfully consolidating power should win elections more often. The absence of increasing incumbent dominance suggests either (1) backsliding is not widespread, (2) it occurs in dimensions not affecting elections, or (3) it is ineffective at its core goal of power consolidation. None of these scenarios supports sweeping global decline narratives.

Indicator family	Strengths	Weaknesses & blind spots
Subjective expert-coded	Broad conceptual scope; detects informal erosion; integrates context; flexible to subtlety	Time-varying standards risk; coder disagreement (SD ~20–25% of scale); replication challenges; sensitive to information environment
Objective factual	Cross-temporal comparability; high reliability; transparent; replicable; immune to mood shifts	Narrow scope (mainly electoral); misses quiet pressure and norms; requires clear definitions; not available for all concepts
What each misses	Objective: civil liberties nuance, judicial capture, subtle media control	Subjective: potential conflation of detection improvements with real change
Best practice	Triangulate across both families; divergence signals need for mechanistic investigation	

Table 4: Indicator trade-offs and what each family can and cannot accomplish

7 Mechanisms explaining the divergence

If subjective indices decline while objective indicators remain stable, two mechanisms merit consideration. **Time-varying coder bias:** The information environment transformed markedly in the 2010s. Social media, improved monitoring, and citizen journalism make

undemocratic actions more visible. Scholarly and media attention to backsliding increased even faster than subjective indices declined (Figure 11 in Little & Meng shows dramatic spikes in Google Scholar hits and news coverage). Under these conditions, equally qualified experts, processing richer evidence and operating with heightened expectations shaped by prominent cases like Hungary, may assign lower scores without corresponding institutional deterioration. This explanation is consistent with: (1) objective stability, (2) subjective decline, (3) media attention increases exceeding empirical changes. **Strategic substitution:** Leaders shift from blatant violations (election cancellation, obvious fraud) to subtle tools (regulatory media pressure, informal judicial influence). Experts detect these, objective indicators do not. However, this account struggles with stable incumbent loss rates. If subtle tools effectively consolidate power, incumbents should win more elections. The evidence contradicts this prediction. Moreover, improved information environments should make subtle violations *harder* to hide, not easier. The coder bias mechanism more parsimoniously fits all observed patterns.

8 Methodological lessons for research design

When constructing trend claims, explicitly document the concept-variable-measure chain and identify what would falsify your interpretation using *both* indicator families. If relying on subjective time series, address coder drift possibilities through sensitivity tests: coder-cohort analysis, placebo period checks, or explicit modeling of information environment changes. If using objective indicators, acknowledge scope gaps and supplement with targeted subjective measures where those gaps matter substantively. Above all, demand convergent evidence: extraordinary claims about global patterns require multiple independent instruments pointing in the same direction, not a single needle that could be miscalibrated. V-Dem's assumption of constant coder bias over time is testable—researchers should test it rather than assume it. For democratic backsliding specifically, convergence between electoral outcomes and expert assessments would strengthen claims; persistent divergence warrants caution about measurement artifacts driving perceived trends.

9 Tutorial discussion applications

Clarifying the validity versus comparability distinction

Students frequently conflate these concepts. Use this test: “If V-Dem perfectly measured democracy in both 2010 and 2020, would Little & Meng still be concerned?” Answer: Yes, if the measurement *standards* shifted. A “7” assigned with 2010 standards might represent worse democracy than a “7” assigned with stricter 2020 standards. This is comparability failure, not validity failure. The variable captures the concept, but the measuring instrument's calibration changed. Analogy: a ruler whose centimeter markings shrink over time still measures length (valid) but yields incomparable measurements across periods.

Evaluating case studies through both lenses

Hungary under Orban: Regular elections, Fidesz wins consistently, but media captured through economic pressure and constitutional changes entrench power. **Objective indicators:** Elections occur, opposition legal, Orban wins but margins vary—appears relatively normal on electoral metrics. **Subjective indicators:** Experts detect informal erosion, rate poorly. This divergence illustrates scope limitations: objective electoral measures miss non-electoral authoritarianism. But note: Hungary is one country. Little & Meng’s claim is about *global* patterns. A few Hungaries do not prove global backsliding without broader evidence.

Singapore: PAP dominance, technically democratic institutions, but gerrymandering and defamation lawsuits suppress opposition. Objective: high winner dominance (flags concern). Subjective: experts note unfairness. Here indicators partially converge, demonstrating that when real problems exist, even objective measures can detect them.

Key readings. Andrew T. Little and Anne Meng (2024) “Measuring Democratic Backsliding,” *PS: Political Science & Politics* 57(2): 149–161. Tutorial slides Week 5, POLI 110.

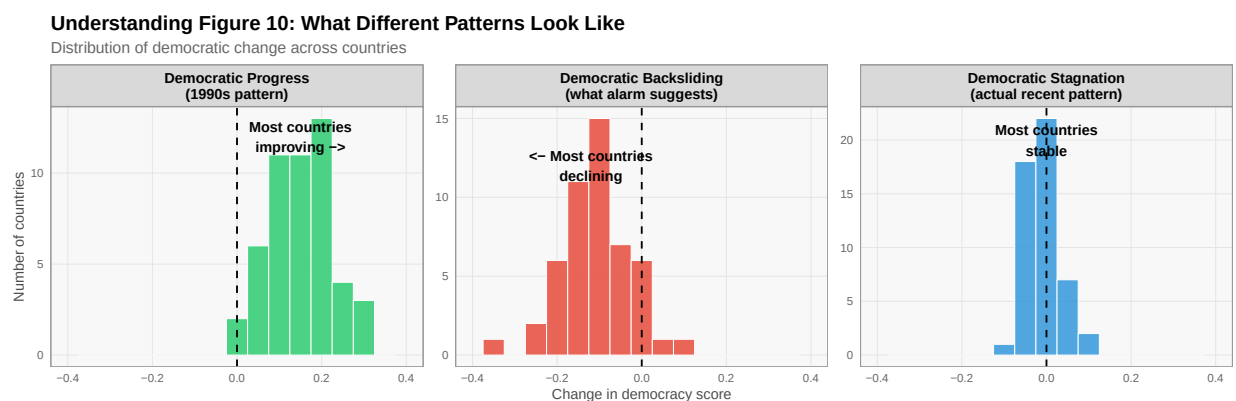


Figure 1: Three Patterns of Democratic Change: Progress (1990s pattern), Backsliding (alarm narrative), and Stagnation (actual recent pattern)